

saver, screen timeout, Find Hub, Wi-Fi calling, autofill, backup, developer options.

This is faster than tapping through six menus and blaming Android. It is also safer because it takes you directly to the relevant control instead of inviting you to fiddle with unrelated switches.

Make this your basic habit: when you hear about a setting, search for it first.

Notifications: stop the daily ambush

Notifications are where Android either becomes useful or unbearable. The default approach of letting every app shout is disastrous, especially in India, where banking alerts, delivery updates, OTPs, WhatsApp groups, shopping promotions, cricket scores, food offers, cab alerts and office messages all compete for the same tiny strip of attention.

Android gives you much more control than most people realise. You can allow notifications from an app but silence specific categories. For example, a delivery app may need order alerts but not promotions. A shopping app may need shipment updates but not sale reminders. WhatsApp may need direct messages but not every group alert. Some Android versions and OEM skins allow fine-grained notification channels, lock-screen behaviour, pop-up control, vibration patterns and silent delivery.

On newer Android versions, notifications continue to become more intelligent. Google's Android 16 feature material highlights changes around productivity, security and notification experiences, including more useful ongoing alerts for supported apps.

Step-by-step: clean up app notifications

- Open Settings.
- Search for App notifications.
- Sort by Most recent or Most frequent, if your phone offers it.
- Tap a noisy app.
- Turn off promotional, recommendation, marketing or “general” channels.
- Keep important channels such as payments, messages, delivery status or security alerts.
- Go back and repeat for shopping, food, travel, video, gaming and social apps.
- Now search for Notification history and turn it on if available.

Notification history is particularly useful because it lets you recover alerts you accidentally dismissed. That one feature can save you from panic when you swipe away an OTP, delivery message, missed call notification or calendar reminder too quickly.

Lock screen privacy: convenience has an audience

Your lock screen is not private just because the phone is locked. If message previews, OTPs, banking alerts, calendar titles or

delivery details appear there, anyone looking at the phone can learn more than they should.

This matters in offices, trains, homes, press events, classrooms, cafés and service centres. A phone lying face-up on a table should not display private financial or personal information to the room.

Search Lock screen notifications. Choose whether to show all notification content, hide sensitive content, or show no notifications on the lock screen. For most users, hide sensitive content is the best balance. You will know that something arrived, but the content remains protected until the phone is unlocked.

Also check whether your phone wakes the screen for every notification. If it does, disable it for noisy apps. A phone that lights up constantly is not smart. It is needy.



Display settings: comfort beats spectacle

Display settings affect battery, readability, eye comfort and how expensive your phone feels. Start with brightness. Adaptive brightness is useful, but it learns from your behaviour. If it keeps getting things wrong, adjust it manually for a few days so the system can recalibrate.

Next, check refresh rate. Many modern Android phones support 90Hz, 120Hz or higher refresh rates. Higher refresh rates feel smoother but can use more battery. Some phones offer adaptive refresh rate, which changes depending on content. For most users, adaptive is ideal.

Dark mode is another setting worth using, especially at night. On OLED screens, it may also help battery in dark interfaces. More importantly, it reduces visual harshness.

Font size and display size are not “elderly settings.” They are usability settings. The most powerful setting is the one that makes the device easier to use.

Sound and vibration: identify what matters

Most Android users live with default sounds until they hate them. Configure sound deliberately. Set different ringtones for personal and work SIMs if your phone supports dual-SIM tones. Choose a notification sound that is audible but not embarrassing